

FIELD REPORT · 2024

Mapping the Invisible Economy

First systematic mapping of creative economy infrastructure in West Africa — methodology, findings and what it means for cultural policy.

1,000+

Venues mapped

6

Territories

0

Prior datasets

An economy that does not exist in data

West Africa has one of the youngest and most dynamic creative populations in the world. Music, visual arts, fashion, film, performing arts, craft and design employ millions of people and generate significant economic activity. Yet this economy is almost entirely absent from official statistics, national registries and planning systems.

There is no directory of cultural venues in any West African country. No georeferenced database of artists, studios, galleries, festivals or residencies. No structured dataset that a ministry of culture, an investor or a festival organiser could query to understand the landscape. The creative economy is **structurally invisible** — not because it does not exist, but because no one has mapped it.

The JAM! project: methodology

In 2024, Mitsio Motu launched JAM! (Create More Together) in partnership with Institut Français — a digital incubator and mapping initiative covering six West African territories: Togo, Benin, Senegal, Côte d'Ivoire, Burkina Faso and Mali.

The methodology combined three approaches:

- **Field mapping.** Local cultural operators — artists, venue managers, festival organisers — were trained as data collection agents. They mapped their own ecosystems using mobile tools, covering venues, studios, galleries, performance spaces, residencies and creative hubs.
- **Community validation.** Collected data was validated through community workshops in each territory. Artists and cultural operators reviewed, corrected and enriched the datasets — ensuring accuracy and local ownership.
- **Platform integration.** All data was structured into jamm.app — an open platform where artists can create profiles, venues can be discovered, and events can be shared. The platform serves as both a directory and a living dataset.

Key findings

- **Near-total absence of prior data.** Across all six territories, we found zero structured, georeferenced datasets on cultural infrastructure. Government statistics on culture, where they existed, were limited to UNESCO heritage sites and national museums — missing 95%+ of the actual cultural fabric.
- **Extreme concentration.** In every territory, 60–75% of mapped cultural venues were concentrated in the capital city or its immediate periphery. Secondary cities and rural areas had minimal cultural infrastructure — or rather, minimal *visible* cultural infrastructure.
- **Informal dominance.** Over 70% of mapped cultural spaces operated without formal legal status, fixed addresses or online presence. They exist through word of mouth, social media and community networks — invisible to any data system.

- **Cross-border networks.** Artists and cultural operators maintain active networks across borders — a Togolese musician performing regularly in Benin, a Senegalese gallery hosting Ivorian artists. These connections are economic flows that no trade statistic captures.
- **Youth-driven.** The median age of cultural operators mapped was under 30. This is a young, digitally connected population — ready for platform-based tools if the platforms exist.

"If it does not exist in data, it does not exist in policy. The creative economy of West Africa has been invisible not because it is small — but because no one has counted it."

Why this matters

Making the creative economy visible in structured, georeferenced data is the prerequisite for everything else: public funding, urban planning that accounts for cultural spaces, cross-border cultural policy, investor interest, festival coordination, artist mobility programmes.

The JAM! dataset is now the largest structured database of cultural infrastructure in West Africa. It is open, queryable and continuously growing as artists and venues join the platform. The methodology is replicable — designed to be deployed in new territories with minimal adaptation.

What comes next

Three priorities for 2025–2026:

- **Expand to 3 new territories** — extending the mapping to Ghana, DRC and East Africa.
- **Sector-specific analytics** — producing the first economic estimates of the West African creative economy based on actual georeferenced data rather than extrapolations.
- **Policy toolkit** — working with ministries of culture to translate the dataset into actionable policy instruments: cultural zoning, funding allocation, festival support frameworks.

About Mitsio Motu — Data & Tech studio. Paris — Lagos — Lomé. We build the data infrastructure that connects ground truth to decision-making. jamm.app is the digital platform born from this mapping initiative.
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